

A framework approach

	 Individual & Family Interventions targeting the capacities, resources, and conditions of individuals and families.	 Community & Relational Interventions building collective capacity, social infrastructure, and relational trust.	 Institutional & Structural Interventions reforming institutions, governance, and the structural rules of the game.
 Protective Reducing the material and structural conditions that drain agency before it can be built	Material Foundations Addressing resource scarcity as the precondition for all other agency	Community Safety Nets Rebuilding the relational infrastructure that catches people before they fall	Structural Enabling Conditions Open systems, fair access, and economic foundations that make resilience possible
 Adaptive Building psychological, cognitive, and relational capacity to navigate adversity and exercise purposeful action.	Individual Adaptive Capacity Equipping people with psychological and cognitive tools to navigate adversity	Community Infrastructure & Social Capital Building the collective capacity and trust that enables communities to act together	Institutional Adaptive Capacity Helping institutions learn, communicate risk, and respond to feedback
 Transformative Removing unfreedoms, restoring rule-making power, and changing the structural paradigms that distribute agency and resilience.	Restoring Autonomy Removing the structural conditions that prevent choices from being genuinely self-determined	Collective Self-Governance Communities holding genuine rule-making power over shared decisions and futures	Systemic Reorientation Changing the rules, incentives, and paradigms that distribute power and resilience

Mission-enabling infrastructure

- **Knowledge & Measurement:** Projects that build the conceptual and empirical foundations the mission needs before it can evaluate anything else. Without robust measurement of agency, the portfolio has no feedback loop.
 - E.g. FocalData research, Policy Atlas
- **Capability & Networks:** Projects that bring new expertise, relationships, and ways of working into Nesta — building the human infrastructure that makes ambitious programme work possible.
 - E.g. residencies, strategy experiments
- **Methods & Evaluation Infrastructure:** Projects that test and improve the tools Nesta uses to design and evaluate interventions — particularly relevant given the methodological challenges of measuring agency and collective resilience.
 - E.g. testing challenge prizes as a method
- **Funding & System Architecture:** Projects that change how social impact is financed and how prevention is prioritised — not direct interventions, but structural conditions that determine whether the rest of the portfolio can sustain itself.
 - E.g. social impact marketplace, rewiring government decision-making incentives towards progressive progression, prototype instruments to encourage longer-term thinking in government

Strategic patterns

Reduce cognitive load so people can act

These ideas assume scarcity, stress or overload crushes agency.

Common theory:

If people have more bandwidth, money, time or stability, they make better decisions and cope better.

Build psychosocial capability

These projects focus on skills like emotional regulation, metacognition, confidence and critical reasoning.

Common theory:

If people can regulate themselves and think clearly, they can better withstand shocks and shape outcomes.

Build collective agency

These ideas treat resilience as something communities do together.

Common theory:

If people trust each other and can coordinate, they handle shocks better and feel less powerless.

Shift institutions, not just individuals

These ideas focus on councils, government, commissioning, procurement, and prevention systems.

Common theory:

Lasting resilience depends on institutions making better decisions, earlier, with citizens rather than for them.

Use innovation methods to unlock resilience

Challenge prizes and experimental methods show up a lot.

Common theory:

Resilience may need new technical or market solutions, and prizes can accelerate them.

Thematic clusters



Early years and family foundations

Build resilience upstream by improving the conditions in which children grow up.



Mental health, behaviour and individual capability

Increase people's ability to regulate, learn, decide and persist under pressure.



Community resilience and social capital

Resilience is not just individual; it lives in relationships, trust and local institutions.



Climate and place-based adaptation

Help places adapt to climate risk in ways that increase both resilience and democratic legitimacy.



Digital and information resilience

Agency increasingly depends on whether people and institutions can navigate digital systems safely and sovereignly.



Institutional and governance reform

Agency and resilience are shaped not only by citizens, but by whether institutions can think long-term, act preventively and share power.

A. Early years and family foundations

Core idea: Build resilience upstream by improving the conditions in which children grow up.

Projects

- Parenting programme accelerator
- Cash + parenting stacked intervention
- Prize on early years brain development
- Unconditional cash transfer trial
- Media for low-income families
- National psychosocial skills programme

Likely impact targets:

- Child development scores
- Parent engagement
- Household stability / reduced cognitive load
- School readiness
- Emotional regulation / self-efficacy

B. Mental health, behaviour and individual capability

Core idea: Increase people's ability to regulate, learn, decide and persist under pressure.

Projects

- MindWorks 2.0
- AI to augment mental health
- GLP-1s for disadvantaged groups
- Metacognition for technological change
- Agency: what drives it / how to increase it
- Boosting capacity for critical engagement with digital/social media

Likely impact targets:

- Mental health and wellbeing
- Emotional regulation
- Self-efficacy / agency
- Behaviour change
- Education / employment outcomes
- Reduced harmful consumption or online harm

C. Community resilience and social capital

Core idea: Resilience is not just individual; it lives in relationships, trust and local institutions.

Projects

- Building resilient communities
- Resilient neighbourhoods / First 72 hrs
- Social capital lab
- Collective identity formation
- Community-led adaptation strategies
- Participatory budgeting
- Collective simulation for crisis resilience
- Collective simulation for democratic resilience
- Shifting Grounds
- Building collective agency in climate-exposed territories

Likely impact targets:

- Trust in neighbours / councils
- Collective efficacy
- Participation in local action
- Mutual aid / volunteering
- Reduced pressure on emergency services
- Better crisis response and recovery

D. Climate and place-based adaptation

Core idea: Help places adapt to climate risk in ways that increase both resilience and democratic legitimacy.

Projects

- Climate resilience challenge prizes
- Clean Heat Neighbourhoods pilots
- Community-led adaptation
- Shifting Grounds
- Climate collective efficacy interventions
- Building collective agency in climate-exposed territories

Likely impact targets:

- Uptake of adaptation / clean heat measures
- Reduced exposure to climate risk
- Trust and consent for local transitions
- Collective action on adaptation
- Better local plans and implementation

E. Digital and information resilience

Core idea: Agency increasingly depends on whether people and institutions can navigate digital systems safely and sovereignly.

Projects

- Prize on quantum navigation
- Boosting capacity for critical engagement with digital/social media
- Public digital sphere / “BBC for social media age”
- Strengthening preparedness in contested information environments
- Reclaiming the digital feed / dark patterns
- Online harms portfolio
- Open data infrastructure
- Policy Atlas

Likely impact targets:

- Reduced online harms
- Greater user control and critical engagement
- Trust in information during crises
- Reduced dependence on fragile / extractive systems
- Better public-sector data sovereignty

F. Institutional and governance reform

Core idea: Agency and resilience are shaped not only by citizens, but by whether institutions can think long-term, act preventively and share power.

Projects

- Testing challenge prizes as a method
- Culture of risk in the civil service
- Getting local councils to trust citizens
- Prevention
- Now for the long-term
- Social impact marketplace
- Residencies

Likely impact targets:

- Adoption of new decision processes
- Better risk communication
- More preventative investment
- Greater use of citizen input
- Better government long-termism
- More resilient funding models

Example ways to spend £2.5-£3m

Resilient Homes, Resilient Families

Build resilience in everyday life by improving homes (energy, comfort, stability) and the family environment for children.

£1.75m	Clean heat neighbourhoods
£1m	Parenting Programme Accelerator
£0.25m	Cross-cutting learning and evaluation

Collective Agency in Places

Strengthen local resilience by enabling communities to coordinate around climate transition and crisis response

£1.5m	Clean heat neighbourhoods
£0.75m	First 72 hours community response model
£0.25m	Crisis simulation for communities
£0.25m	Evaluation / playbook

Early Agency and Family Stability

Reduce stress and cognitive load in disadvantaged households while strengthening parenting skills to improve child development and long-term agency.

£1m	Parenting programme accelerator
£1.25m	Cash + parenting stacked intervention
£0.5m	Mealia pilot or family stability evaluation

Digital Resilience and Public Safety

Strengthen citizens' agency and resilience in digital environments by reducing manipulation and improving critical engagement.

£1m	Digital critical engagement interventions
£0.75m	Dark patterns / reclaiming digital feed
£0.25m	Crisis information resilience research
£0.5m	Online harms portfolio

Prevention and Better Government

Improve how institutions anticipate risk, involve citizens, and invest in prevention to strengthen systemic resilience.

£0.75m	Risk culture for civil service
£1m	Long-term policy tools, prevention system reforms
£0.5m	Citizen participation experiments
£0.25m	Policy Atlas & residencies